

macOS Spotlight Tips and Tricks



Basics

Cmd + Space	Open Spotlight
¹keyword(s)	Display results for search term with first result highlighted and its preview in right-hand pane
“keywords” or “phrase”	Display exact matches
²“as”	Display App Store as top result
²“pc”	Display Parental Controls as top result
Return (Enter)	Open selected item
Double-click result	Open selected item
Down Arrow	Select result below
Up Arrow	Select result above
³Tab	Select first item in preview pane
⁴Cmd	Display Finder location of selected result at bottom of preview pane
Right Arrow	Autocomplete search keyword using the suggested/selected result
Cmd + Down Arrow	Jump to first result in next category
Cmd + Up Arrow	Jump to first result in previous category
Cmd + L	Jump to definition in results
Cmd + R	Open result in Finder or relevant app if applicable
Cmd + Return (Enter)	Open result in Finder or relevant app if applicable
Cmd + I	Open Get Info pane for result
Cmd + B	Look up search term using default search engine in default browser
Cmd + C	Copy item
Drag result to Finder window or desktop	Copy item
Double-click Show all in Finder in results list	View all results in Finder
Hover over preview for audio/video result	Reveal Play button to play result in preview
Two-finger scroll over preview	Reveal scroll bar
Drag search box	Move Spotlight to reposition it
Esc	Clear search box
Cmd + Delete	Clear search box
Option + Cmd + Space	Open Finder search window with search box selected

⁵Search Using Metadata Attributes

from:Name	Created or sent by Name
by:Name	Created or sent by Name
author:Name	Created by Name
to:Name	Addressed to Name

title:Title_Name	With title Title_Name
tag:TagName	With tag Tag_Name
date:DD/MM/YY	From DD/MM/YY
created:DD/MM/YY	Created on DD/MM/YY
modified:DD/MM/YY	Modified on DD/MM/YY
⁶comment:keyword	Comment contains keyword
kind:app kind:application(s)	⁷ Apps
kind:audio	Audio
kind:bookmark(s)	Bookmarks
kind:event(s)	Calendar events
kind:contact(s)	Contacts
kind:document(s)	Documents
kind email(s) kind: mail message(s)	Emails
kind:folder(s)	Folders
kind:font(s)	Fonts
kind:image(s), kind:jpeg, kind:png	Images
kind:movie(s)	Movies
kind:music	Music
kind:pdf(s)	PDF
kind:preferences kind:system preferences	Preferences
kind:presentation(s)	Presentations
kind:reminder(s)	Reminders
kind:pages	Pages documents
kind:numbers	Numbers spreadsheets
kind:keynote	Keynote presentations

⁸Search Using Boolean Operators

keyword 1 AND keyword 2	Results with keyword 1 and keyword 2
keyword 1 OR keyword 2	Results with keyword 1 or keyword 2
keyword 1 NOT keyword 2	Results with keyword 1 but not keyword 2
keyword 1 -keyword 2	Results with keyword 1 but not keyword 2

Tools/Math

Get time zone information	“time in Sydney”
Get weather information	“weather” for local weather “weather in Mumbai”
Look up definitions	keyword
Convert temperatures	“302kelvins in f”
Convert measurements	“52 pounds to kilograms”
Convert currencies	“600gbp in usd”
Get math calculations	“234/5*6”

Get real-time sports scores	“cricket scores” “lakers game”
Get stock prices	“sbux” for SBUX or Starbucks Corporation
See what’s playing at local theaters	showtimes or movie times
Get movie details and showtimes	“men in black”
Track flights	“WN3536” or “southwest 3536”
⁹Play songs without opening iTunes	“waka waka”
¹⁰Find local businesses	coffee places to eat restaurant salon “starbucks” “apple store”      

Search Using Natural Language

emails i received today
photos from yesterday
files from this week
messages from last week
screenshots i took last month
last year photos
unread emails
pictures i took in june
documents i created in 2019
“spreadsheets from tim”
“presentations from ben”

¹Keyword(s) can be in title of Finder item or within content.

²Speed up search for apps and **System Preferences** panes by typing in their initials. Works with third-party apps also.

³Works with folders only. Preview pane items can be enclosed files or subfolders.

⁴Works with local results only.

⁵Can be used with or without keywords.

⁶Searches for Finder items with keyword in **Comments** section of **Get Info** pane.

⁷Without this filter, searching for an app name also reveals files recently used in app and matching apps in Mac App Store.

⁸Can be used with metadata attributes.

Eg: kind:document date:25/08/19-31/08/19 NOT 28/08/19

⁹Hover over relevant track in preview to reveal **Play** button.

¹Look under **Maps** category for relevant results. Does not work with all emojis.

- A. Feature availability might vary based on country.
- B. Visit **System Preferences > Spotlight** to Toggle visibility of Spotlight categories.